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Jane Bunnett

Jane Bunnett has established herself as a superlative soprano saxophonist/flautist, and composer. Her passion for Afro-Cuban music led to partnerships with Cuban musicians and the creation of the ensembles Spirits of Havana and Maqueque. She frequently collaborates with her husband, trumpeter Larry Cramer.

Jane was interviewed via Zoom on January 25, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I've already had a fun conversation with Jane Bunnett, but we'll keep going.

JB: Okay.

MR: You're in Toronto and I'm at Hamilton College in Clinton, New York, and I'm going to introduce you as a soprano saxophonist, a flute player, band leader, and an expert on work visas and passports from other countries. That must be tough.

JB: Yeah it has been, you know, to do all — you know it's hard enough touring but to do all the extra work that, you know, that we've had to do to get people, you know, into Canada, into the U.S. It's been an ongoing thing for probably forty-something years. I mean our first time, Larry and mine — my partner, trumpet playing producer husband first went to Cuba I guess '81, '82 and that's when we sort of got very, you know, it was a huge surprise going to Cuba and, you know hearing the music that we were hearing and as we continued to keep visiting it was just, we kept discovering more genres of the music and, you know, I've always, we've always been interested in the history of jazz and then you get into the history of Cuban music and it's so deep and rich and it's just a beautiful journey. But then we established our very first group, Spirits of Havana, with a whole bunch of young — not all young people but some older legendary musicians that came through Spirits of Havana that are no longer with us on Earth. But in some ways all that work, it did establish us as doing something a little different than other people were doing in the jazz, on the jazz scene. First of all I consider myself a jazz artist. That's why I, you know I love the music so much. I love improvising. And I love the history of jazz. And then getting into the Cuban music, you know that's when we started, as we learned more and more about the genre, to bring our ideas into the many rhythmic concepts and the history of Cuban music. So that's been that journey. And it's always sort of gone alongside of some of the other more straight ahead musical endeavors if it was playing with Paul Bley or Don Pullen, Stanley Cowell, Dewey Redman, Billy Hart.

MR: Can I ask you about the learning process, being a schooled musician, that's such a — not a helpful term but I'll use it anyway — learning the Latin rhythms and making them rhythmically become inside you. Did you try to figure it out from actually like transcribing things?

JB: Maybe, maybe some vocal — some of the vocal things when I got very interested in the Afro-Cuban folkloric music so I would transcribe maybe some of the vocal lines because of the melodies that were so lovely and some of the Afro-Cuban chants. But both musics, I am not an academic and I'll be totally honest with that. In terms of my jazz studies, not an academic. The way that I got into the music was when the various musicians would come to Toronto to play, we had a place called the Colonial Tavern and sometimes there was like a five night run there, and there was a Saturday matinee. And as a younger person you could go to the matinee. And my father and my brother took me a few times to the matinees. I met Mingus — I heard Mingus, Rahsaan Roland Kirk, Horace Silver, Mose Allison, a long list of music until I got older and then I could go into the clubs by myself. But when I really got hit, you know, with the jazz bug, because I was doing classical music, I guess it would be like in my very late teens so I'm like 19, 18, 19 when the musicians, when I just started to play jazz and I would go to hear the guys and I would ask for a lesson. And that's how I learned. You know like I had lessons when James Moody came to town, when Frank Wess came to town, Clifford Jordan would come over here. It was always in an aural manner. And they'd write things down for me and Barry Harris — I went to a number of his classes. Same way with the Cuban music. When Larry and I started going to Cuba we went directly to the musicians and basically hung out with them. Took our instruments, went, you know into the barrios and played with some of the folkloric musicians. I would take my tape recorder and tape stuff. So it's all been absorbing and it's all been spending time in the locale of where the music is being made or with the people that are making it. That's always been [inaudible] and this was also happening before there was music — there wasn't a jazz studies program when I started playing jazz. Now they're all over the place. There was North Texas State I know they had a big band program that played jazz charts and stuff like that, but that was not like — there wasn't a place where you could go study, you know, small ensemble playing or learn the language of jazz. It seemed so foreign. But I always — I guess, and I always say I'm a people person but I always was attracted to the people that were making the music and that's what drew me in and made me study what they were doing and learn in that fashion.

MR: What was the biggest difference from playing — from coming from bop or, you know, standard jazz tunes that we're used to playing, and going down there and sitting in with

those musicians and you've mentioned the word "folkloric"? How did you have to adjust?

JB: I guess the biggest thing would be putting myself in the zone of what they were doing, adapting, listening, of course listening is a huge part of any musical study. Spending — a big thing for me has always been spending time with the people as people and not just running in, absorbing the music and taking off you know. It's been a bit of a 24/7. You go over there you're drinking some rum with them and then the music activity happens and then you're spending more time with them afterwards and say, "Ah — I'll see you tomorrow, I'll be back." So there's like — people throw that word around — organic process — but it really has been for me and for Larry just like that with a big lump of time and a commitment to just letting things unfold and if you're invited — you know hopefully you're invited to participate. There's some times I haven't been invited to participate — it might just be listening and absorbing what I can.

MR: I'd like to read something here. Victor Rendon is a percussionist who I believe lives in Brooklyn and he's the leader of the Bronx Conexion Latin-Jazz Big Band. And I asked him a similar question about learning it and he said, and I'll paraphrase here, in Cuba it's by rote. It's an oral tradition what they do, the novice would basically sit there or maybe stand against the wall and listen, pick it up by ear. If they were not an annoyance they would let you stay there and then maybe you would get to play.

JB: Yeah. That's right on. I totally hear him, yeah that's exactly what it is like. Yeah. I mean and that's not, you know, that's not far off from the early jazz traditions too right? You know getting up on the bandstand and if you suck you're off. If you even get that opportunity.

MR: Yeah the famous cymbal throwing at Charlie Parker. Was the format, I remember a few years ago there's a group, a professor here who does early American music and they had a little quote jam session with fiddle and violin and they were playing these tunes from — Americana type tunes. And I took my soprano sax and I thought — I sat down with them. But I couldn't fit in because I thought well all right, when is it my time to solo here. It wasn't like that.

JB: Uh huh.

MR: They were playing melodies over and over and then they might switch to a different melody but it was just like I'm lost.

JB: Yeah. I understand that. Yeah. Well I understand that because you were maybe coming at it from it's — I understand it I just don't know quite how to put it in words. Because sometimes you just have — it's not like — you don't get to shine and do your thing. It's more so you just kind of interweave through what's already happening and that's — I

one of the scenes in the pubs there where the musicians are all playing — like everybody's just sort of like — they're planning and they're improvising but they're all playing their part. And it's not like any point like somebody — somebody might take over for a minute and have their thing happening but generally it's just like everybody just pooling their sounds. And you just weren't comfortable with that. So who knows, like if you had a couple of more opportunities you would have figured out how to, you know, kind of inject yourself into that situation that felt just kind of how am I going to do my thing, like the thing that I do.

MR: Yeah it's not like play the head, everybody take a solo, play the head.

JB: Yeah.

MR: Exactly.

JB: Yeah well I guess you know in some ways that's why some people find jazz really boring just because of that. You know some younger people just find that — no, okay, here comes the bass solo, yup.

MR: Time to talk.

JB: Yeah. Oh dear.

MR: Did you run into a situation where you learned that some of this music I'm playing has a spiritual connection to it and this feeling like I should know about this and maybe I should be more careful with it?

JB: Absolutely. I know exactly what you're saying and that has hit me many times because it is so, you know this word we use expropriation etcetera, that you can be involved but not understand the deeper meaning of what it's about and that it could come off as disrespectful or misinterpreted or any number of things. I guess in the case of that, because I guess you're talking about the Afro-Cuban music because a lot of the music is from a very deep spiritual religious context. I guess I look at the musicians around me to inform me, you know, if there's some—to inform me and also to inform myself, to be inquisitive and interested enough to go deeper into what I am trying to perform. I mean it's a tricky question because I play, you know I have done a lot of work with the Afro-Cuban chants and, you know arranging the music that I'm hearing, and that music is for spiritual practice and the history, you know goes back hundreds of years. And at the same time I'm not a practitioner of Santeria or Afro-Cuban music but the melodies are so beautiful and the rhythms are — you know it's so open for improvising and, you know, it's coming from the same root of course as jazz music. So I just, you know I try and inform myself as much as possible and of course be surrounded by the other musicians that will, you know, I've often found when I have been performing that sometimes the guys are like so, so happy because they feel the music, what I have been doing has

being practitioners it has enhanced the music to who they are acknowledging. But it's interesting, these things you do.

MR: Does it swing? Does the music swing for you?

JB: It's different. I mean it can in a way but you can hear that sort of underlying it but there's always just the, a lot of the time in the music there's so many subdivisions so rhythmically it's more so like, it's vibrations. There's like just kind of I don't know sometimes I felt very, very energized from playing the music, that it has given me something back. And it's a different kind of thing. Yeah.

MR: I have another quote.

JB: Swing is hard too, You know I'm still trying to get it together.

MR: Well here's what drummer Ed Shaughnessy had to say. I asked him what is swing and he went on for quite a while so I'll just — he says, "Now I think bluegrass music swings like hell. The main thing that swing means for me is it's infectious, a beat that makes you want to move, it gets you going. So any music like bluegrass or jazz or funk or Watusi music communicates to you rhythmically and gets a visceral thing going. That's what I think swing is."

JB: Yeah. Perfect.

MR: Thank you, Ed.

JB: He hit it right on. Yeah.

MR: When you were, I don't know if it's recruiting if I can use that word — young women to fulfill your vision was there a question about like what did their parents think of this idea, did you describe the life of a musician — here's what you're getting into?

JB: No, not at all. I just hoped that their parents wouldn't get in the way and try and stop it, but generally, you know Cubans love music and you know it's so deep in peoples' lives. That that's one of the things I've loved so much about Cuba is everybody loves music. And if you're a musician they sort of welcome you with open arms. And any person, you know if it could be somebody working in a restaurant or driving a cab, like all the people know their music and know the musicians and have their opinions on who's good and who's bad. It's not like in North America where you could ask somebody what their favorite song is and they're like, "I don't know" or ask them a musical question, "Who do you think are the best ten such-and-such." People say, "I don't know." "What's your favorite music?" "I don't know." But there everybody has an opinion and is passionate about music. So the parents are, generally the parents are pretty, have been pretty down and involved in making it happen for them.

MR: When did you, if you'll remind me when you first went over there.

JB: So it would be around '81, '82.

MR: Because Ignacio Berroa, the drummer, actually left there on the Mariel boatlift because he felt like he couldn't stay there and play because the government frowned upon — well he said first The Beatles, they frowned upon The Beatles, but also any jazz type music that seemed like too — you know we call it democratic or based on meritocracy or whatever. But he felt I have to get out of here.

JB: Yup, that's very true. Paquito too and you know so many of the musicians, yeah, it's very true. There's no doubting that's a fact. And you know some people were totally blackballed, you know like blockaded from doing — the government just had the power to just say no, you're not going to play. And that actually went on for quite a few years even after, you know a lot of those great musicians left for the U.S., you know people, I know a lot of musicians that somehow were able to hear jazz through Voice of America on the radio and that was the only way they were able to hear it, and people smuggling Beatles and BeeGees. I don't know if that's it for the music scene. No offense BeeGees, but — love the BeeGees. But, and it's been hard, even for a number of the musicians that Larry and I have worked with over, you know forty years, when we started to go there I was taking, I remember taking my fake book down with all the standards and stuff like that, and that was something that was just impossible to get and musicians taking photos with their cameras of the fake book and went, "Oh 'All The Things You Are'" and taking shots so that they could go get a photo of a tune so that they could learn the tune because they wanted the music and by every means necessary these guys were searching out music from outside of Cuba.

MR: I can almost picture you being in customs, going in at the airport and uh oh, you've got the E flat Real Book here.

JB: Busted.

MR: Busted.

JB: Yeah. It's been really difficult and blocked. You know like when we made our first record, Spirits of Havana in Cuba, the group Yoruba Andabo which is pretty well known Afro-Cuban folkloric group. Now they were not allowed to go into the recording studio which was called the EGREM. The government had taken over former RCA Victor Studios. And they weren't allowed to go in because they were looked at as only being dock workers and, which they were, they all worked at the port. They collected, became a drum collective and resurrecting a lot of the old rumba music and playing on the boxes, the cajons. They weren't allowed to go into the studio. A lot of red tape had to be cut so that they had on their identity cards that they were allowed to go in. So those were like extremely extremely tough times for many, many artists.

MR: Let me ask you about your composing process. There's a couple of things that I really

sax. And also unison string bass and left hand piano on occasion. Where do your compositions come from? Are you inspired by anything in particular?

JB: Pretty much everything. I know that's sort of a typical question, but that's a hard question Monk, because I think like I mean I just feel like I'm influenced by so many things that I just hear, particular pieces like Pharoah Sanders and Leon Thomas, "The Creator Has a Master Plan." I think of that, I think of Duke Ellington "Money Jungle." I think of McCoy Tyner — what's it called that tune? "Fly with the Wind." I think of Don Pullen especially, you know his music, which had a huge effect on me. Carla Bley — like everything. Everything. Everything — I just find everything informs me really, to be honest.

MR: Do you go to the piano first?

JB: I sort of go between the two. Sometimes it'll start with the piano. Sometimes it might start just with the horn noodling like on the last record, you know, and that was sort of a lot of the music was written during Covid, I would just be sitting up in nature with my horn and I'd just start playing a line and so a seed of an idea came and I'm just — you know work for that sort of maybe for an hour or so and then maybe later in the day go down to the piano and say oh let's see if I can figure out a bass — what am I — where is this going? So I go between the two things. Might start on the piano, might start on the horn.

MR: Do you have a tonal center for you? Like you're out, like you say, going out to nature and you start — and the reason I'm asking that is I watched one of your performances that came from the Registry Theater.

JB: Oh boy, that's a while ago.

MR: In Ontario. I played in Kitchener actually.

JB: Really?

MR: Many moons ago. But you had a long introduction on this particular tune. And I'm watching you and I'm wondering what are you thinking?

JB: Was that with Maqueque or was that with Spirits of Havana?

MR: Spirits of Havana.

JB: Okay. I betcha — I wonder if it was that song called "The River."

MR: It didn't have a indication of the title unfortunately.

JB: Sounds like me. Forgot to introduce it. Yeah. I like doing intros. I like to kind of set up an atmospheric thing before it gets crazy. Just, you know, like I like to paint and it's the same thing, like when I compose I try and look at it like it's always like my first piece and my last. Like this is the first thing and probably the last thing I'll ever write so let's make it like special and make it like a story, make it a statement, make it — create

thing that was not there before and hopefully is memorable, you know, that is like just special.

MR: You just rang a bell with me. I think memorable is very important. As the song is done can you remember anything from it? Sing it back.

JB: Yeah, that is very important to me, especially nowadays because there's just so much. You know we are bombarded by so much stuff, right? Sensory overload, if it's visual, if it's audio. And of course everybody's different. What's memorable for one person is not, you know, some people find the theme from "Cats" memorable. I want to — double shoot myself. No offense Webber.

MR: Wait 'til we're done, okay?

JB: But anyhow, you know everybody is different, so for me I like things that are singable, even if they're really difficult and whacky sounding. I mean I find some of Ornette's — you know some of his heavier stuff, I still find it really memorable.

MR: Do you and Larry comment on each other's music and composing and so forth.

JB: Yes we sure do. He's my worst critic and I'm his worst critic. Larry's — but you know what it's really, really great because yeah — his taste — he started working at a record store when he was like 15 years old and he's attended way more jazz performances than I have because he was like in his late teens he was already going out and driving to Buffalo with people to hear — to hear Freddie Hubbard or to hear some of the greats that were playing. And I was still kind of back listening to, you know, my Joni Mitchell records and Bob Dylan before I got deeper into jazz. You know I came at it from a very eclectic record collection because I kind of liked all kinds of music when I was young. And my big brother Peter Bunnett, he was a pretty strong jazz fan and into beat poetry and he had everything. And I used to just love going into his room and pulling records out and putting them on and seeing what else was out there. So — but what I'm trying to say is like Larry is very — I think he's got very great taste and big ears and has heard a lot of music.

MR: Does the — are you asked like I'm about to ask you — about the women in jazz, the state of women in jazz?

JB: Yeah.

MR: How do you feel about it right now?

JB: Well I feel great. If there's a festival it's a women's festival that I'm playing at it. If it's a women's festival and I'm not playing at it I hate it.

MR: Here's a quote from a fairly recent *DownBeat*. I believe it's about Maqueque. "Band of young killer female musicians play like seasoned veterans. This music is a real treat." From *DownBeat*. Do you think we'll ever get to the point where they could say that same

JB: I don't know.

MR: And would it be better? Or doesn't it matter?

JB: Yeah, it probably would be better but you know just at the same — I don't know. You know I look to somebody like Terri Lyne Carrington to answer those questions and I really admire her because she has been so honest and forthcoming about what she came up through. You know she was a brilliant, talented 10-year-old or however old she was when she, you know her family was like so totally behind her. And you know so many of the musicians took her under their wing which is just marvelous because she's just like one of the most consummate musicians in the world. And at the same time she totally understands what's happened and what's happening for other women that maybe have found it really hard and had to be so hard-nosed and tough to persevere, you know. You know everybody's story is so different and everybody's — it's hard enough, you know, to play jazz and improvised music without having those blocks up, those things in front of you. And it's still a really hard question for me to answer because I've been fortunate in that I surrounded myself with — most of the time — musicians that were extremely kind. I'm talking about male musicians, really kind and generous, and motivated me and inspired me. But it's not always like that. I mean I've had a few experiences but they have been very few where I really have been up against somebody extremely negative and I didn't feel I conducted myself in the best manner that I could have because I don't have a skin built up for that and I really lost it and got very angry with the person in a public forum because I was feeling — I won't go into things but there has been a few things if it's been a jam session or it's being in a situation where it felt I was being, you know the hand was coming and I was being — I had no control and that was upsetting. And then there's also you know sometimes, you know that the thing that happens — now I'm jumping to just the opportunities — if it's a festival and you hear back now people are very guarded now, they don't so much talk like this now, but we've already got out headline woman performer. You know? So I mean I feel like when we started Maqueque I felt like I was pretty much ahead of the curve of the Me Too movement and in fact I don't really know really too much about any all-women Latin jazz ensembles, Cuban musicians that are out there. So I felt — I did feel like I was working against that barrier to do some festivals with my group and the tricky thing for me is that entering the U.S., once the band goes into the U.S. with the visa situation I sort of have to stay there. To come back into Canada I have to buy new visas and also have had to petition the State Department to go in with Maqueque to perform in the U.S. Now a couple of my band members are now are American citizens. They applied for asylum there and they got it. But still this is what we've been up against, you know up until two years ago just. And

be Canadian, because I'm out of — I know you're looking at me funny there. But yeah, because I'm not on the — that's sort of changing a tiny bit now too but you know New York is very centric to hey we don't know about you — yeah. We don't know about you. I'm not on the New York scene. I'm in Toronto. I'm based here. I'm Canadian. I remember Paul Bley telling me to take it out of my bio, take it out, take the Canadian out. Bless Uncle Paul we call him — take it out. You know? I remember him telling me to get an American address. Just get a box number in New York City, it's so much better than saying you're Canadian.

MR: Well Paul Shaffer didn't take it out.

JB: This was Paul Bley.

MR: Yeah.

JB: Paul Shaffer. I say hey man, Paul Shaffer's Canadian.

MR: Let me ask you about dance. This is an odd question. Do you and Larry dance?

JB: I love to dance. Larry not so much.

MR: Okay. I saw one video of you playing in — I don't know if it was a club or whatever. And people were dancing.

JB: Yeah.

MR: And I love playing for dancers. I think it effects the band positively if things are in sync.

JB: It's really true. I like playing for dancers too. Yeah, I really do. Yeah a lot of the time at our shows people will get up and dance, it depends on the particular city. Some cities are more — have a tendency to more kind of hippies and those folks come out. But yeah, I mean I remember Barry Harris and I think a lot of other musicians of that era, the late Barry Harris saying that you know when people stop dancing, you know when the bebop started to really develop people stopped dancing and that was a really unfortunate aspect for the music because it sort of then kind of made a distance between the musicians and the audience members. And that's why it's great, I don't know if you ever knew Fred Taylor, a wonderful man who booked Sculler's in Cambridge, Massachusetts but he was one of the first guys to put on shows with tap dancers and some of the drummers. I'm sorry I can't remember — I want to say Jo Jones but I don't know if it was Jo Jones. I think it might have been Jo Jones. And Jimmy Slyde and some of the great dancers, tap dancers. That was really, what do you call it — a collaboration, a beautiful collaboration.

MR: When you get in the studio with your group, do you have a technique to create the kind of spirit that happens live?

JB: That's a great question. Try to. I think we try to but that's — you know I guess it really depends on the conditions around the recording and how much we've rehearsed you know because we've been up against — when we did our last record we only had a

up after Covid. We only had a couple of days to do our recording so a lot of stuff was worked out in the studio, as opposed to other recordings where everybody has lived in our house and we, and that situation was always kind of different because we'd be waiting for the visas. The girls would go for their interviews at the U.S. Embassy here in Toronto. We would have to wait a couple of weeks before the approval and being able to pick up the visas. In that time we would be rehearsing every day, so — from morning 'til, you know, end of day. And really, really workshopping the music and playing and experimenting and then, you know the visa thing would happen and then we'd go out on the road and do a tour, come back and do the recording. And so then it was so easy to be able to just — because we were so seasoned with the music and it was so under our belt and everything, to make it feel like it was live in front of an audience because we just was coming off the road and feeling really fresh and had tried so many, you know, every angle to shape the music and create something new. So generally the ideal thing is to do it like that I think. Yeah.

MR: Has it ever been an odd feeling for you to — I won't say correct — but to make suggestions to your fellow musicians who grew up with this music and you want something different from them?

JB: Yep. That's a great, that's a wonderful question. And only a musician, like you, would say that question. Yeah. Because I am a jazz musician and I'm hearing it come — I'm hearing what I hopefully want to do coming through having listened to Coltrane and Pharoah Sanders and Sam Rivers and McCoy Tyner. And just a long list of musical greats. And what you can do with simple melodic ideas, but beautiful harmonies, focusing on beautiful harmonies and then building on all the rhythmic beauty that Afro-Cuban music has to offer, you know all the subdivisions and the — yeah. So, and of course in the Afro-Cuban music sometimes the clave is like really predominant and I've had a few times where I've written something and it might fall out of clave and the musicians will be playing something and they'll be shaking their heads going, "It's not working, this isn't working because it's not in the clave" and da-da-da-da. And then it just takes a little time sometimes to think it out and say, "Oh, well if we just put another bar right here and then the clave — I could still keep the melodic idea — the idea can still happen but it'll just –- but it'll hook up again with the clave, you know in the next bar, or however bars it's going to take before it lines up again." And they go, "Oh, that works." So there's rule breaking but within the creativity there's somewhat some rule breaking but you know you have to be respectful of, once again, the genre. Does that answer the question?

MR: Yeah. Years ago when I was booking groups for school shows we had a group come from Albany, Alex Torres and the Latin Kings. It was wonderful. And I got aggravated with myself because there was some times I couldn't find one.

JB: You're not alone.

MR: And they go, "Just listen to the clave." And I'm watching and I go wait — no one's playing the clave specifically.

JB: Yeah.

MR: It's still a bit of a mystery to me but it's so — as Shaughnessy said, "It's so infectious after a while" he says, "I don't know where one is but it sure feels good." So.

JB: That's so true, it really is. Yeah. Sometimes you can't — you can feel it, and your body feels it, if something like goes off, right? It's like having two left shoes on or something like that.

MR: Just this morning I was listening to one of your videos and I couldn't really find where one was but I all of a sudden noticed that my foot was tapping, so, very unconsciously.

JB: Uh huh. Interesting.

MR: I'm not sure what the conclusion is there but.

JB: It does take time, you know. Cuban music came more quickly to me than Larry in terms of the clave and stuff. But for me, when Larry plays a beautiful feeling of swing and sometimes I don't feel as comfortable, you know, as he is with finding the pocket in music that is more, you know, in the pocket swing. It's something that you have to spend a lot of time with and work on.

MR: Is it a challenge — you're both practicing musicians and artists. I think I know the answer to this but is it a challenging way to make a living?

JB: Sure is. Really is. Especially right now. You know because the — how do we say it — not the template, but what has worked for so long does not work as well anymore. So what we've been conditioned in the last — rehearse a band, go out on tour, come home, make a record, everybody you know goes and does their own thing for a bit, then come back together. Yeah, it's — with the clubs, you know so many of the clubs, arts presenters, funding cut back for the art presenters received. It's in a changing environment for artists and so many of my peers are teaching in universities and they're doing academia to supplement their musical activities. They have to teach. Some people are better teachers than others. And it's just different because I look at all my musical heroes and the only one I can really think of who taught was Stanley Cowell, the late Stanley Cowell. He was at Rutgers. And he did that because you know I think he found the touring life, you know he had a family and he found the touring life really strenuous. You know he was out on the road with everybody — the Heath Brothers and Rahsaan

Pullen and John Hicks and Billy Hart — all these great musicians that I admire, they've all just lived off their musical performance. Their playing. Their artistic endeavors. Their creative drive and their expertise in being hired. That's gone. So I don't know. It's just different to really have to, in my case I'm trying to maybe open up a bit more to collaborating with more musicians and so that will allow me to stay in a creative space which is what I really thrive on. I love collaborating, I love throwing ideas out and then getting them thrown back and people adding to make something — enhance it, make it better. I don't thrive in academia. I still love going out with young people and doing clinics. Like I do a clinic or a workshop but I could not do a full time musical — hold a teaching position. Because it's just not in my creative spirit.

MR: Have you ever had a student at one of these perhaps workshops ask you if you use a particular jazz technique and you don't really know what they're talking about? I mean it's happened to me. Something that they've learned from a book or some video on YouTube. So when do you use that?

JB: Yeah. Well I have to be honest, you know if I'm aware of something. You know to give you an example, Jamey Aebersold, Like Jamey Aebersold — look what Jamey Aebersold has done for the jazz world. I just think the guy is incredible. You know so many people, he made those instruction books, those play-a-long tapes. He has like created a forum for so many people that are just like — if they're amateurs, if they're young students — to get their skills together. To get their confidence up. Even if you could — to go to a jam session and be able to play one piece at that jam session because you've like practiced your butt off doing Jamey "Uh one, uh two, uh one … " You know if somebody tells me they used this stuff I say that is just fantastic. But have you listened to, like you listened to "Silver Serenade?" You know they're playing that tune or that's just an example. But have you heard, have you heard Horace Silver actually play that tune? So I try not to discourage people if there's things that are inspiring them but take it further. Always try and, if you can, go to the source and actually a couple of times students have pointed something out to me that I was like, "Oh that's pretty cool, gee I didn't know that." So I've actually sometimes learned something you know. Because they're out there on all that stuff. Like they're mad men, right, just checking all that stuff out. And that's great. So you've got to have a balance.

MR: Yeah. So you're at a cocktail party and somebody who's fairly well off gets to know you a little bit. And they say, "So Jane, my niece is a good saxophone player and she wants to be a jazz musician. What do you think about that? What should she do?"

JB: I would say, I would give that person my phone number and say have her call me. That's exactly what I'd do and that's what I've done. Here's my phone number. Here's my

see where they're coming from. I've got a number of young people that call me that are just sort of embarking on maybe, you know, going out there and doing something. But you know unfortunately there's also a lot of fear of failure and of course everybody — well not everybody because I know people that are fearless, so I'm not fearless. If I'm really, really — what's the word called — inspired or my vision is so so strong about something I will pursue it. But you know I fear often of failure and I think now that is at just an all-time high and also there's the other side of that where there's just plain kind of ignorance and just sort of people that haven't put the hours in and don't have the respect for the music in that I feel you should have, and for the history of the music that are out there just glutting the market with terrible stuff. You know really really bad stuff. So there's a fine line between the two things. I mean it's just you have to be authentic to yourself and if I see somebody who's really pursuing something and serious about it I'll do everything I can. I was — Dewey Redman and Don Pullen they were very big mentors to me and they were probably two of the heaviest musicians sort of out there on the scene. And they were so encouraging to me. So I feel like, you know, if I can try and be like that I should try and do the same thing.

MR: Yeah I'm happy to hear that. Because sometimes the same question another musician would be much more not encouraging. "Well you just better be aware that" this and that.

JB: Yeah I mean I don't think there's any point in telling people that because like you know there's just no reason to discourage somebody. If you don't make it you don't make it. You know what I mean? I don't know, I don't agree with that. It's not in my nature to discourage people. They'll find that out for themself, you know what I mean? You don't need to tell anybody — and everybody of course develops at such a different pace. I, you know I didn't pick up my soprano sax until I was, I think I was like thirty — I'm just trying to think how old I was. I was maybe like thirty — what's the math? I bought my horn in '78 so what's the math on that. "88, '98, so I bought my horn in 1978. I'm 68.

MR: Why didn't you become a jazz pianist?

JB: I had more — I had tendonitis and — yeah and I was studying classical piano and I had a very — a rebellious adolescence. I went to five high schools getting kicked out of a few of them. And I really loved art and my last year, I guess it was in an art school and I thought I wanted to paint. And I always thought I want to do this, I want to do that. And I finally got serious about piano and I went at it a little too vigorously and I developed tendonitis and then I had to take time off from the piano. I did finally get my Grade Ten Piano Studies which was a big deal for me. But then I realized you know I was not going to be in that forum. I was not going to be a classical piano player. Everything — it was not. So I went to San Francisco and heard Mingus and when I came back from that trip, I

wanted to play jazz. And I bought a flute around that time and started kind of like tinkering around on the flute. And then friends from school just on the weekends somebody would be playing, you know a couple of guitars and a bass player and we'd just be jamming on two chord things. And I don't know what we were playing. But anyway and I would play the flute too but I really didn't know what I was doing, but having a great time doing it. And so then I just sort of transitioned then. I started to put the things together. Coming back from San Francisco I remember telling Don, because he was in the shows in San Francisco that I thought all the — I thought Mingus's band was all classical musicians. I thought they were all studied classical musicians. I didn't — you know I didn't realize that there were different skills to do that kind of thing than there is to playing — I'm sure, Don was a classical piano player and he said he thought that was hilarious when I told him that. But yeah, so I transitioned and then I just started like by hanging out in record stores and pulling a record, "Who's this guy Charlie Parker? Can you put this on?" And then being humiliated by the guy, "You don't know Charlie Parker?" Yeah, I remember having the Joni Mitchell record with [sings] "My analyst told me."

MR: Yeah.

JB: Yeah. Hendricks and Ross, Annie Ross. And I remember saying, "Wow I really love this record, Joni Mitchell sings like "My analyst told me" and the two guys that ran the store just looked at me like they just wanted to toss me out the place.

MR: Don't you know?

JB: "Don't you know?" And they went over to the thing and like held up a Hendricks and Ross — Lambert, Hendricks & Ross record and so there was a lot of humiliation in going through the steps. But all these people were — like I was willing to learn and they were willing to put records on and so I just went at it like that next. That's how I sort of transitioned. I still love to play piano but you know if I sit at the piano for too long working on something my wrists are achy.

MR: Well I want to wrap up with two quick things. One is just an observation. I watched your group play the NPR Tiny Desk and after the first tune I was informed by watching you that it was a lot of work because you were really out of breath. Do you recall that?

JB: No. I'm going to check that out.

MR: Well you should watch because it reminded me of watching — one time I was in the wings at a dance company thing and you know they were so graceful and stuff and they came off stage and they were panting and sweating. And I said wow, this is a lot of work. And that you put an awful lot of physical effort into the music.

JB: Uh huh. This is true. Yeah.

MR: So the other question is, this is a little like off-topic, but I'm also interested in what artists think about other things. Down here in the States, on occasion when people get concerned about politics and the way things are and what's going to happen if this happens, "I'm going to have to move to Canada." That's a thing that we sometimes say.

JB: Yeah. Not so easy.

MR: Yeah. Do you have any observations on watching what's going on in the States?

JB: Wow. Yeah. It's sad. It's really sad. And right now we're having, our elections are coming up in the next couple of years and so we've got to, we don't have a lot of choices right now but it's certainly nothing like what could possibly happen in your fine country. So it's absurd. I don't know. Yeah I've heard that so much from friends that are saying, "I'm coming there." It's like well the borders are not so easy to come through. You know the borders are definitely tightened up on both sides for sure. It's not so easy for me to come into the U.S. either.

MR: I see. Well keep making music and hope for the best.

JB: Yeah. I've so enjoyed speaking with you today. It's great to, you're not only a wonderful interviewer but the fact that you're coming at it from knowing about the music and artistically the thought process that we as musicians go through. It's so interesting always to answer those kind of questions because sometimes we just take it for granted in our own development and musical journey, how you think, you know. So it forces you to think about how you think about what you do.

MR: Yeah also, you can't see it but on the wall in front of me I have four pages of information about you including your awards and nominations, and the fact that you can share a record display with your band on top of Duke Ellington and just down the road from Art Tatum.

JB: I know. Isn't that sort of self-gratification. It is. I got this. And then I've got some of the great people that —

MR: Oh Benny Carter. Yeah.

JB: This crazy, this Slim Gaillard —

MR: Oh yes.

JB: So Slim lived off and on with us for four years.

MR: Is that right?

JB: Oh my God. What an incredible whacky time that was. And then we got to work with the great Hermeto Pascoal. Had a big concert here with him. And Jon Hendricks — did some shows with Jon Hendricks here. Of course Stanley Cowell, one of my heroes. Stanley Cowell, made a beautiful, beautiful record. And this was one of the most inspiring records for me, that was Don Pullen's solo record. That was sort of in between — that

MR: Well young musicians will be holding up your records and say, “I played with Jane.” So thank you for your time. This has been delightful.

JB: Monk, thank you. I really enjoyed it and I hope we get to meet in person sometime soon. That would be so great.

MR: Right. Best of luck with you and your group and Larry.

JB: Thank you. Thanks a lot. Keep in touch, okay, and I’ll continue to watch your awesome video interviews.

MR: All right. Over and out.

JB: Okay. Thanks so much.